Music Production: Start to Finish

Introduction

This guide will walk you through the complete process of creating your first music production from start to finish. Whether you're interested in hip-hop, electronic, pop, or any other genre, these steps will help you transform a blank project into a polished track. This guide is designed for beginners who have access to a computer and are ready to dive into music production.

What You'll Need:

- A computer (Mac or PC)
- Headphones or studio monitors
- A Digital Audio Workstation (DAW)
- Internet connection for downloading samples
- Approximately 4-8 hours to complete your first track

Step 1: Choose and Set Up Your DAW

Objective: Select a Digital Audio Workstation (DAW) based on your budget and music style.

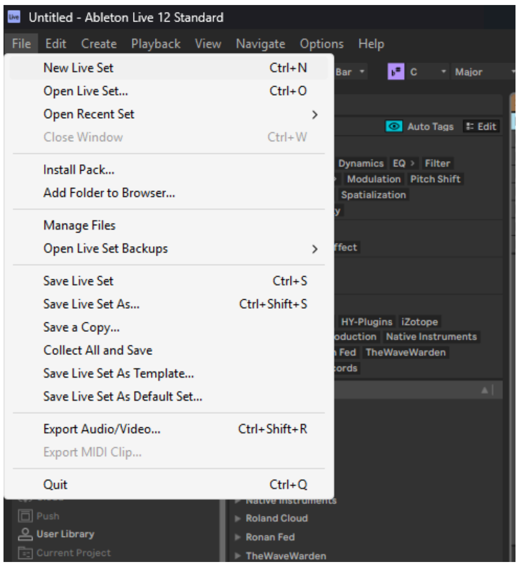
Recommended DAWs:

- **FL Studio** - Best for hip-hop and electronic music
  - Fruity - $99
  - Producer - $179
  - Signature - $269
  - All Plugins - $449
- **Ableton Live** - Ideal for electronic music and live performance
  - Intro - $99
  - Standard - $439
  - Suite - $749
- **Pro Tools** - Industry standard for recording and mixing
  - Artist - $9.99/mo
  - Studio - $34.99/mo
  - Ultimate - $99/mo
- **GarageBand** - Free option for Mac users, great for beginners
- **Logic Pro** - Professional option for Mac users

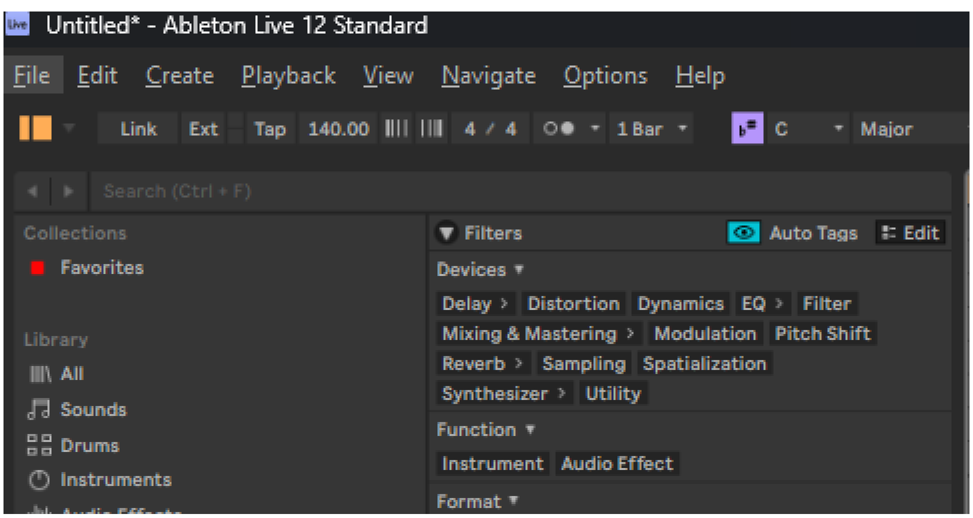
- $199

Setup Instructions:

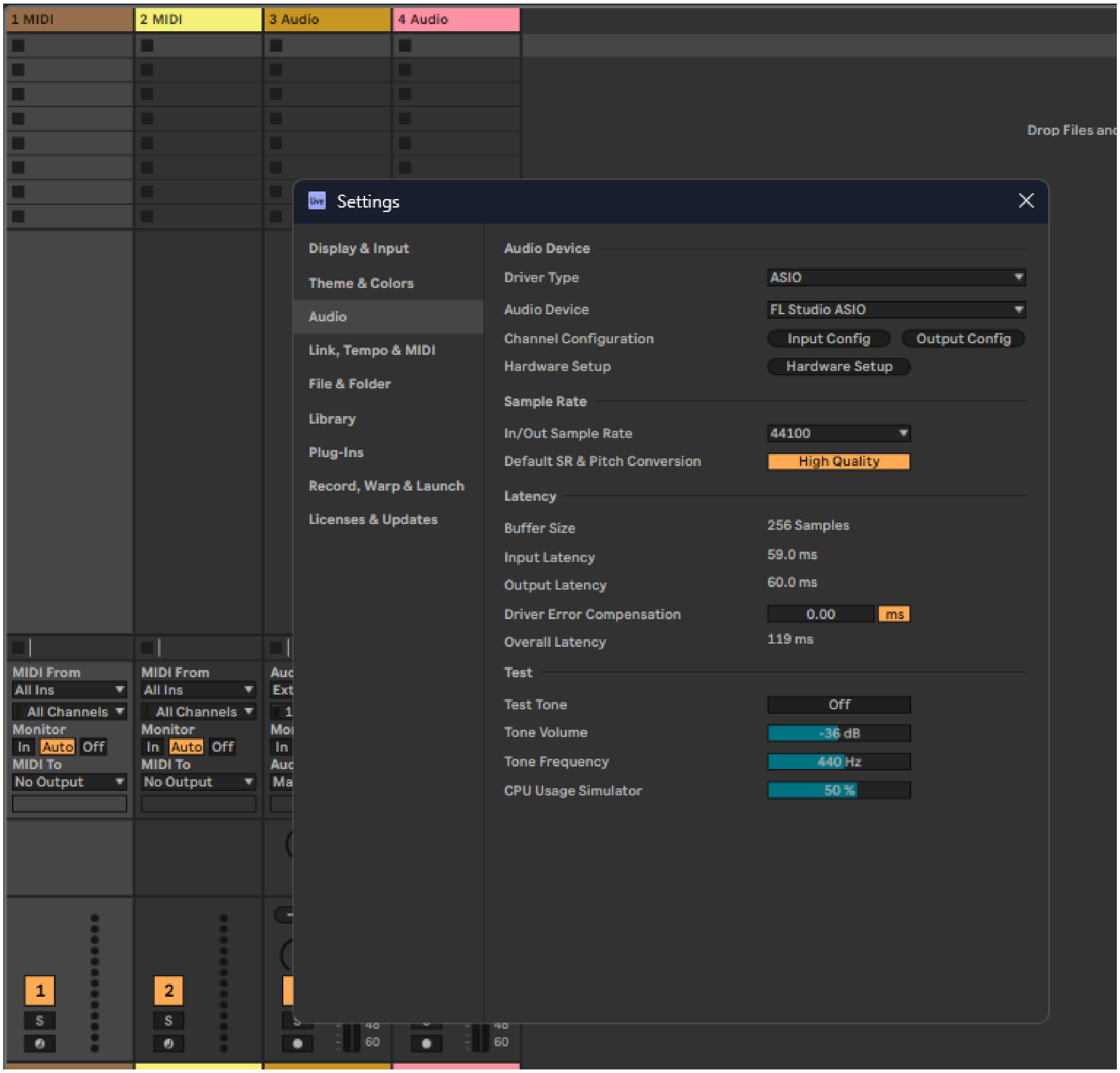
1. Download and install your chosen DAW from the official website.
2. Open the DAW and create a new project (New live set in Ableton)



3. Set your project tempo (BPM). Start with 120-140 BPM for electronic music, 70-90 BPM for hip-hop, or 100-130 BPM for pop. In this example, we set it to 140bpm



4. Set your sample rate to 44.1 kHz or 48 kHz in the audio settings. (Typically already set to 44.1kHz by default)



5. Save your project with a clear name. How you name your projects is a topic for debate but how I've done it for 6+ years is the [DATE]-[VERSION]-[GENRE] (e.g., "10-5-25-2-HipHop-Beat"). For me, I make a lot of different projects on the same day, and sometimes I like to make them in different genres. Also it removes the block of coming up with a name on the spot.

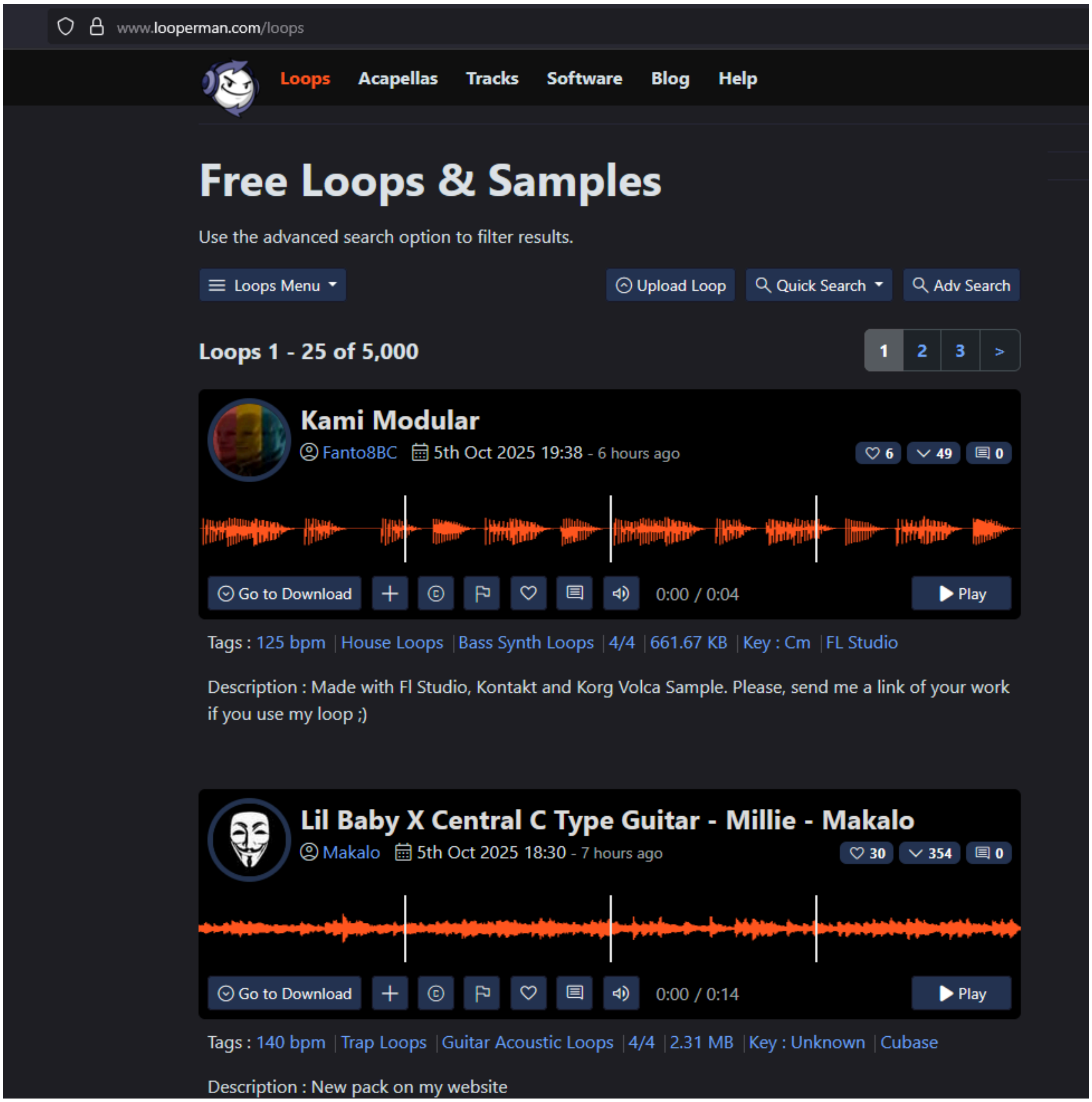
Step 2: Gather Your Sound Palette

Objective: Build your collection of sounds before you start producing.

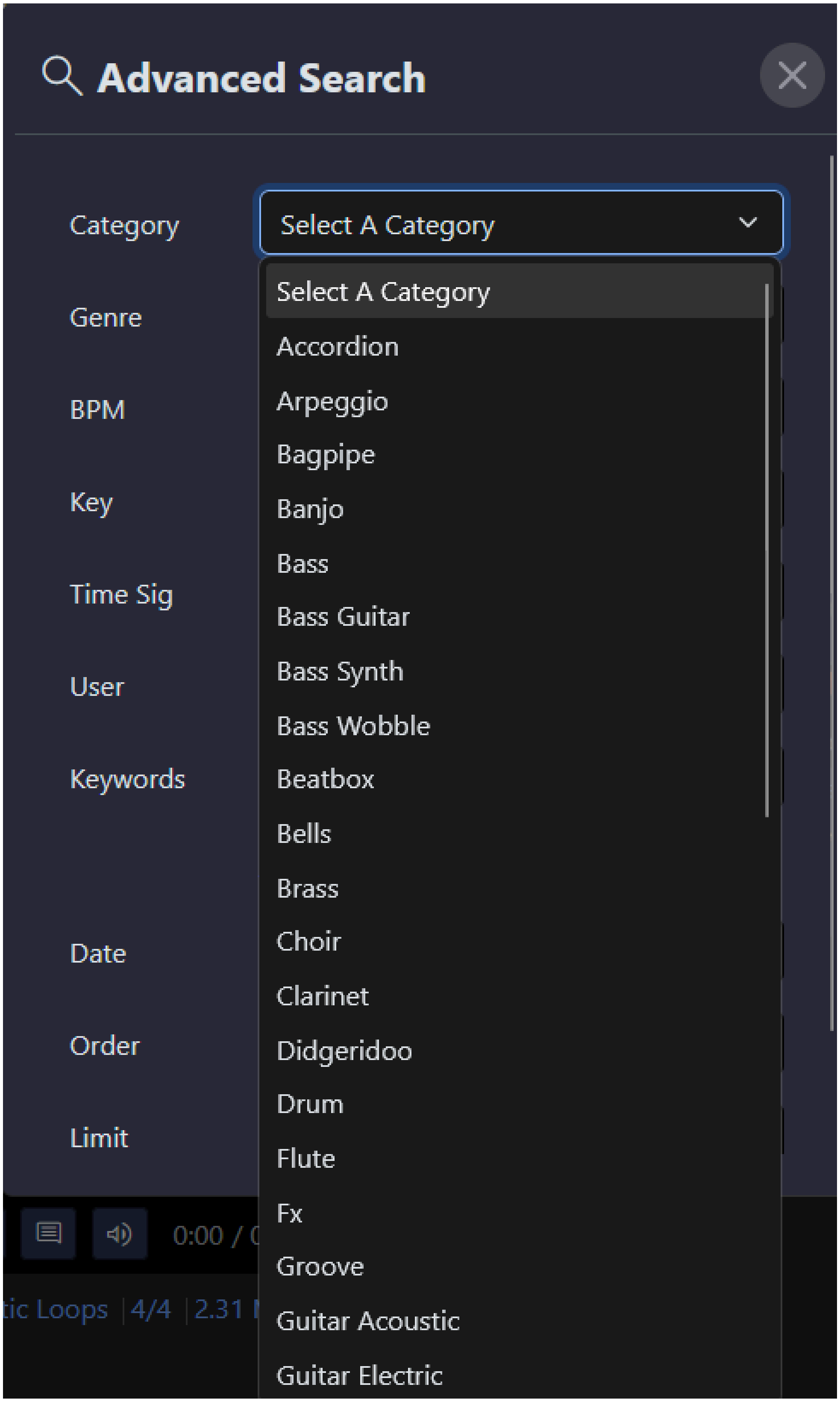
2a. Finding Pre-Made Samples

Option 1: Free Sample Sites

1. Visit Looperman.com for free royalty-free sounds.



2. Browse by genre or instrument type.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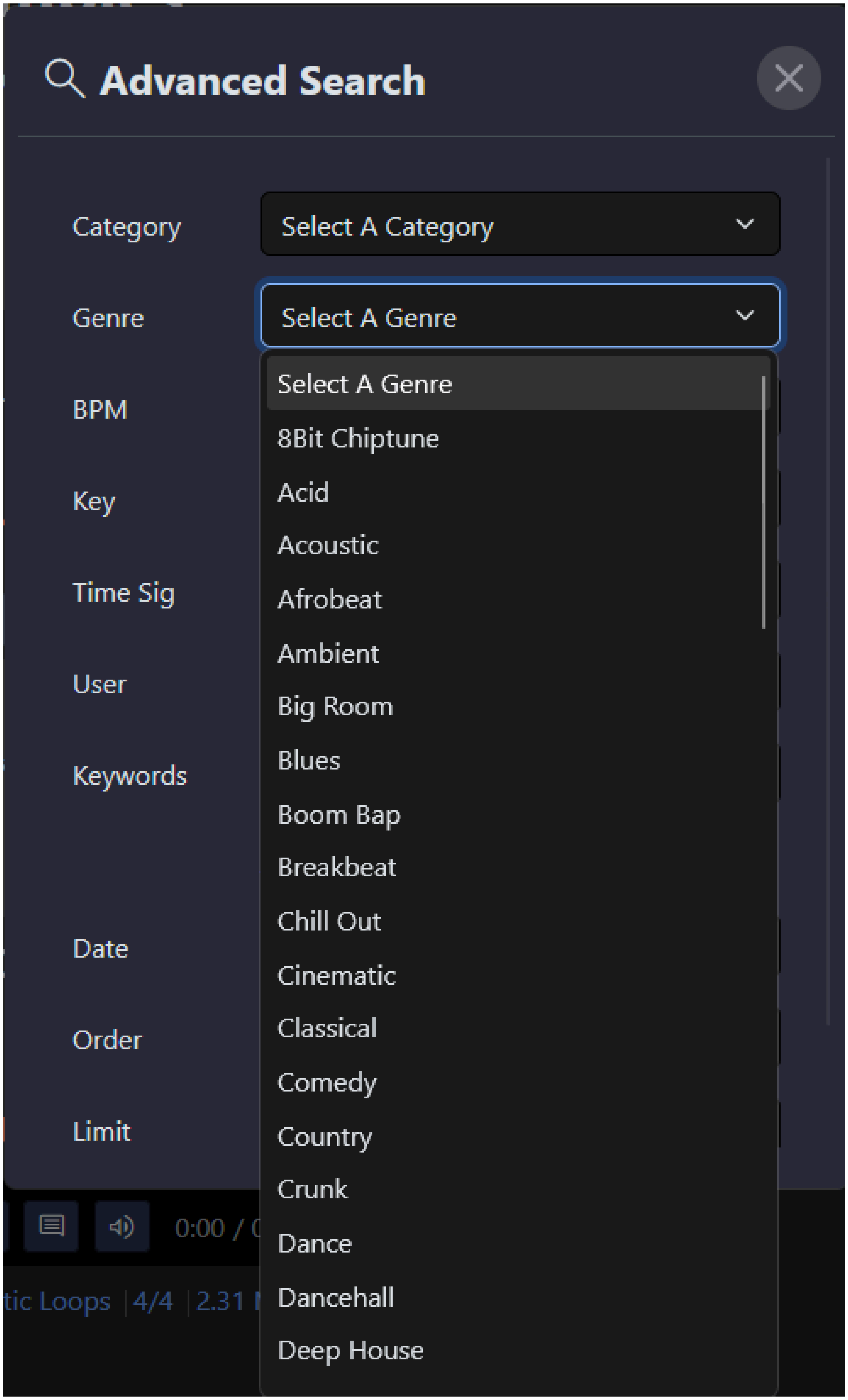
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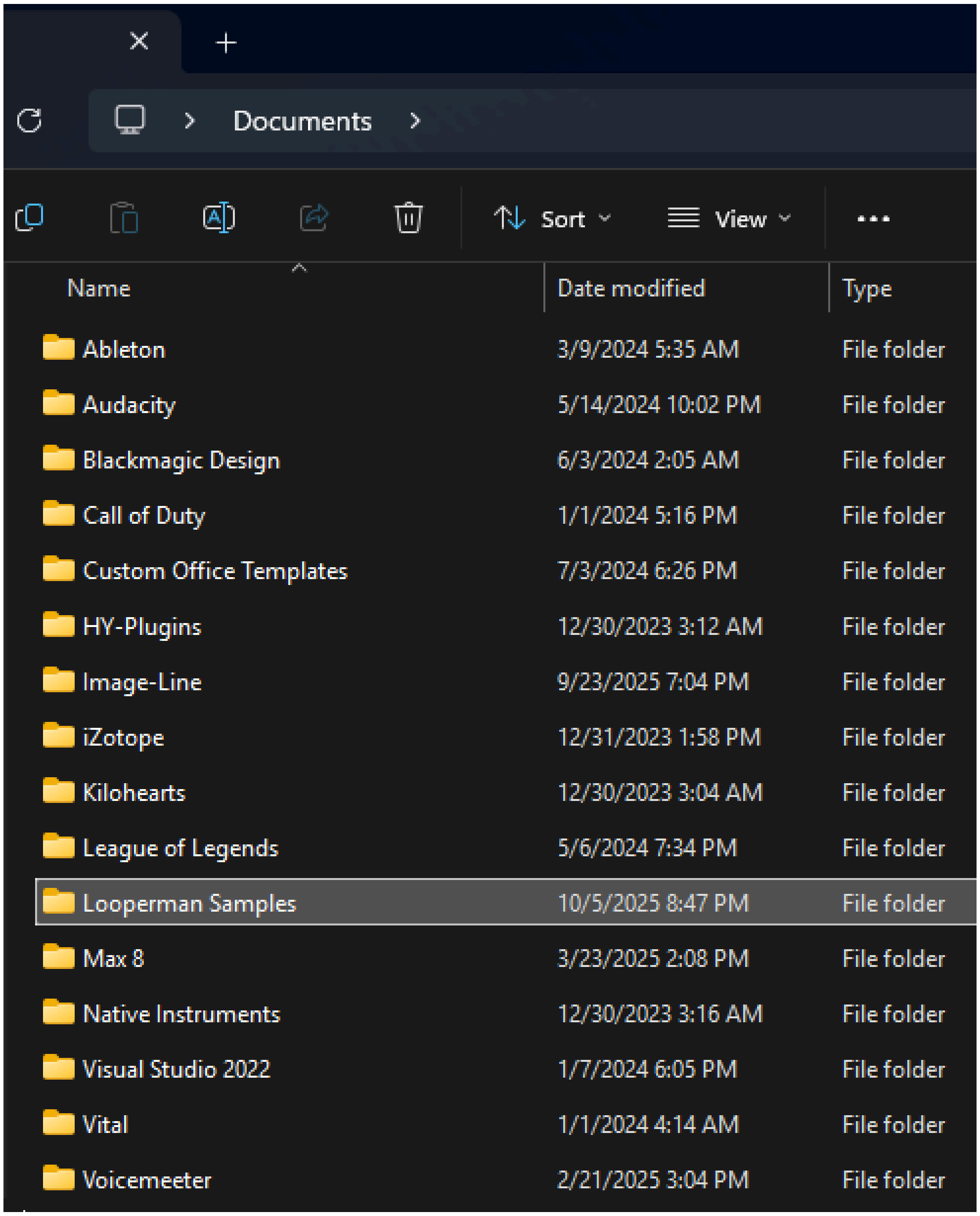
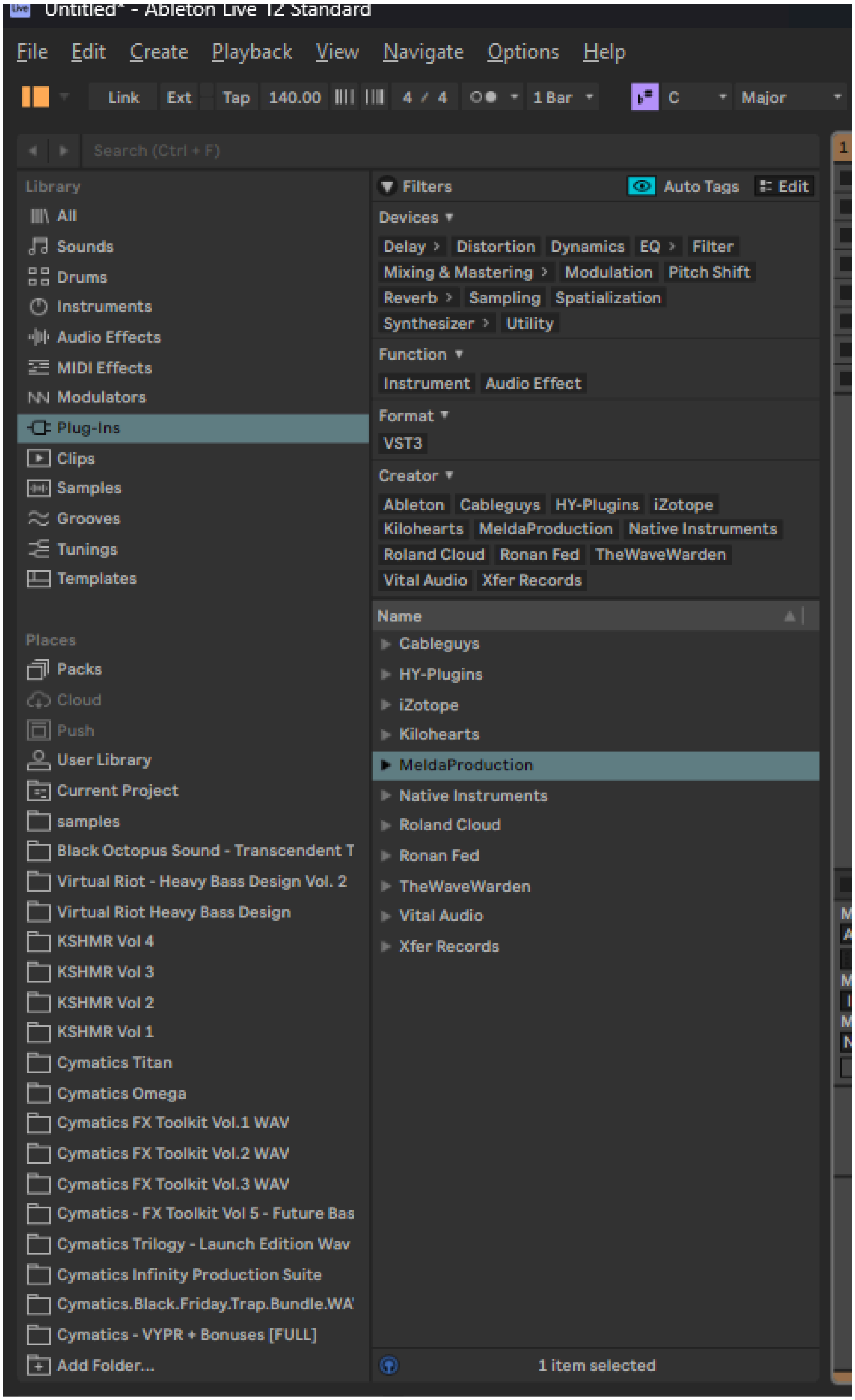
Afrobeat
Ambient
Big Room
Blues
Boom Bap
Breakbeat
Chill Out
Cinematic
Classical
Comedy
Country
Crunk
Dance
Dancehall
Deep House

3. Download 5-10 drum samples, 3-5 melodic loops, and 2-3 bass sounds.
4. Create a folder on your desktop containing your newly downloaded samples.

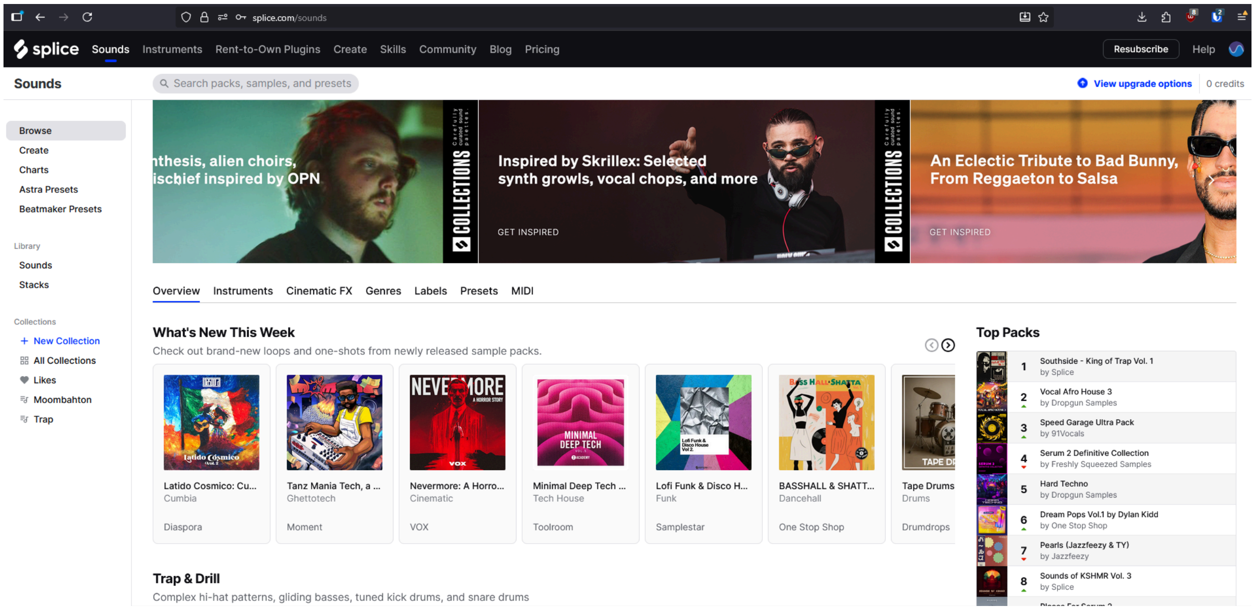


5. Import your folder into your DAW. (In Ableton, it's under packs all the way to the bottom left where it says Add Folder)

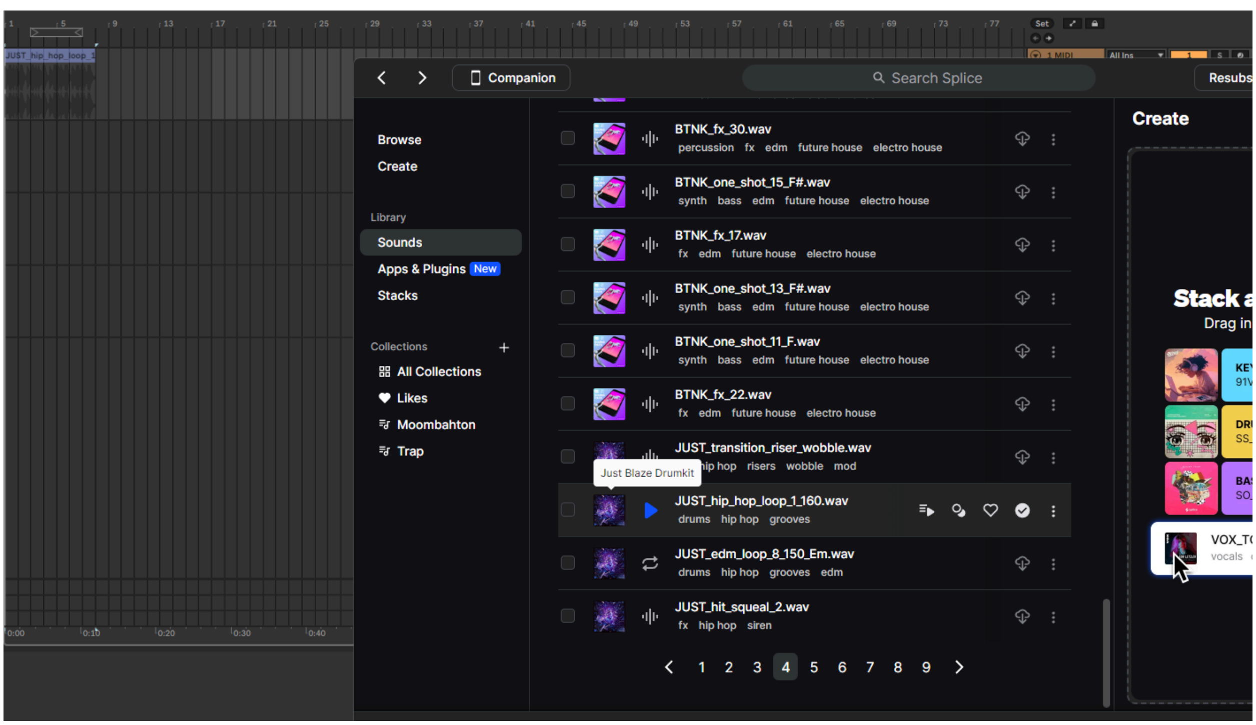


Option 2: Premium Sample Libraries

1. Sign up for Splice.com (subscription required).



2. Download the Splice desktop app.
3. Search for samples by genre, BPM, or key.
4. Drag samples directly from the Splice app into your DAW.

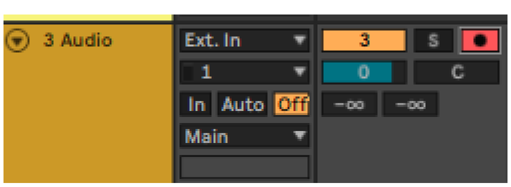


2b. Creating Original Samples

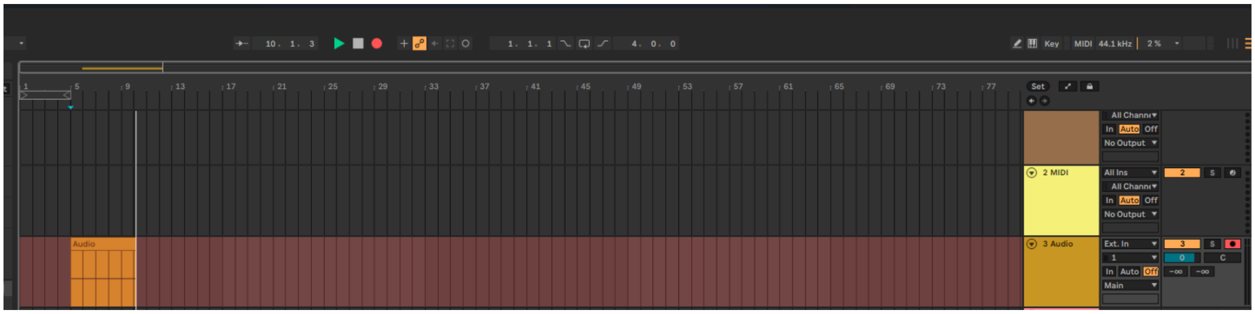
Recording Live Instruments:

1. Connect your instrument or microphone to your audio interface.
2. Create a new audio track in your DAW.

3. Enable recording on the track (press the red record button on the track).



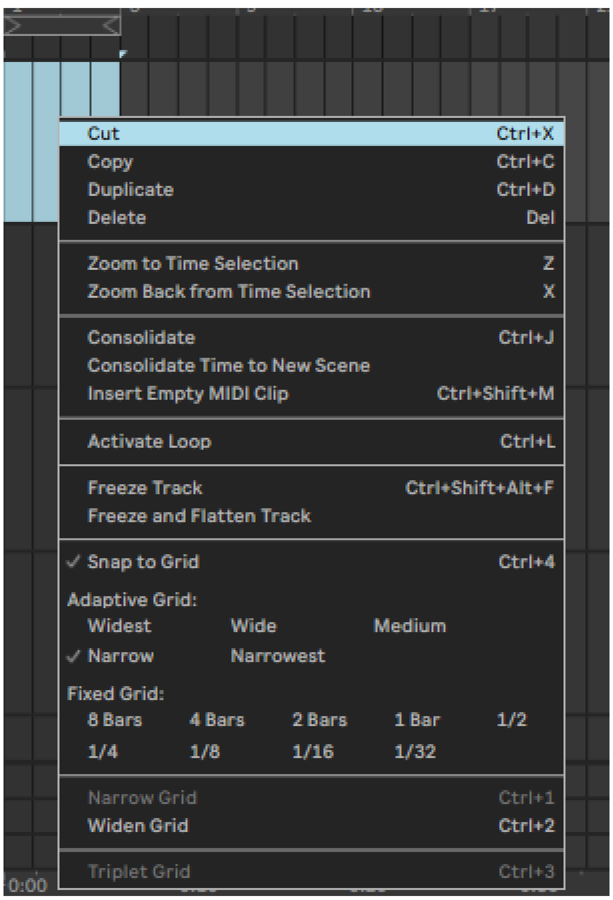
4. Play a 4-8 bar loop of your melody or rhythm.



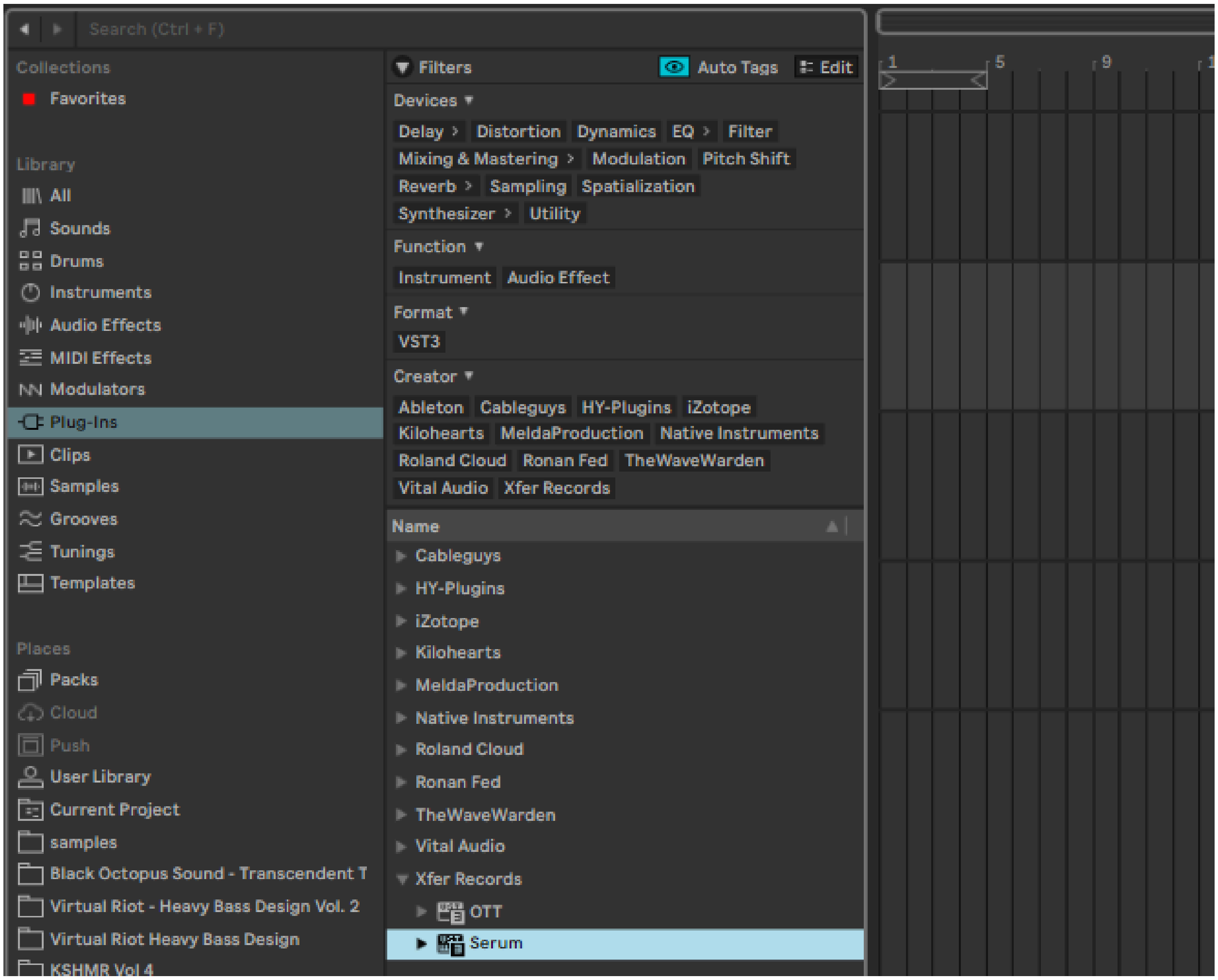
5. Listen back and keep the best take.

Using MIDI and Virtual Instruments:

1. Create a new MIDI track in your DAW.



2. Load a Virtual Studio Technology (VST) instrument (piano, synth, guitar, etc.).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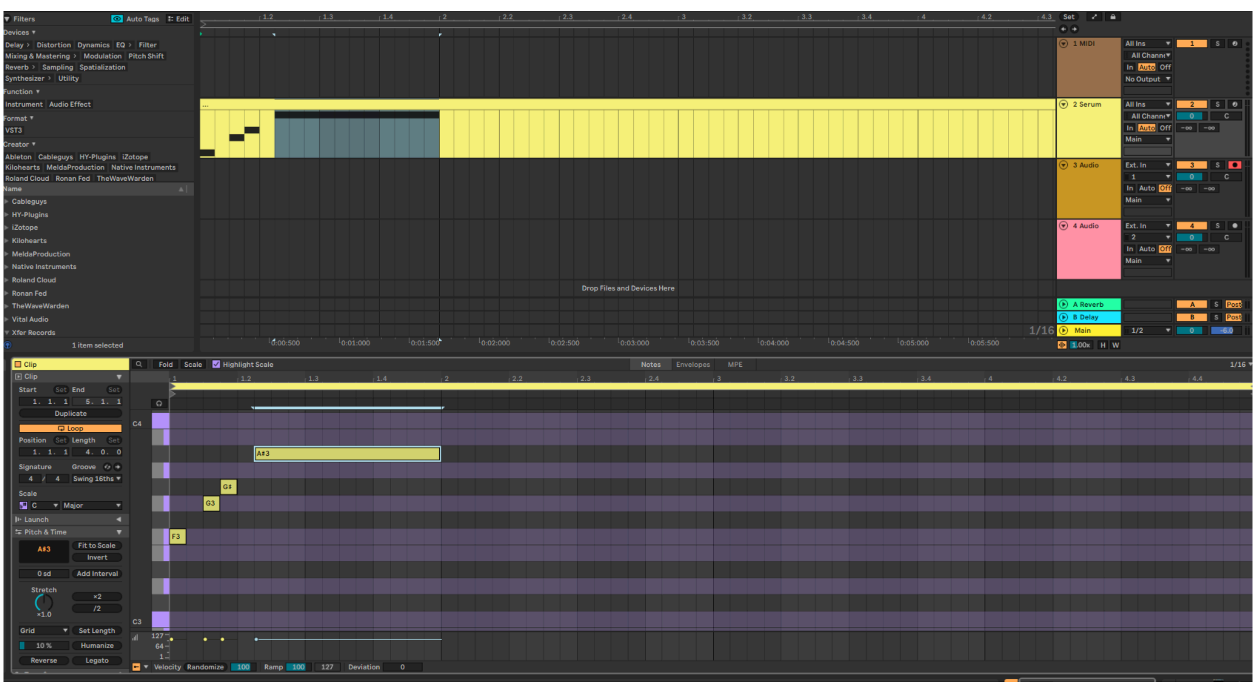
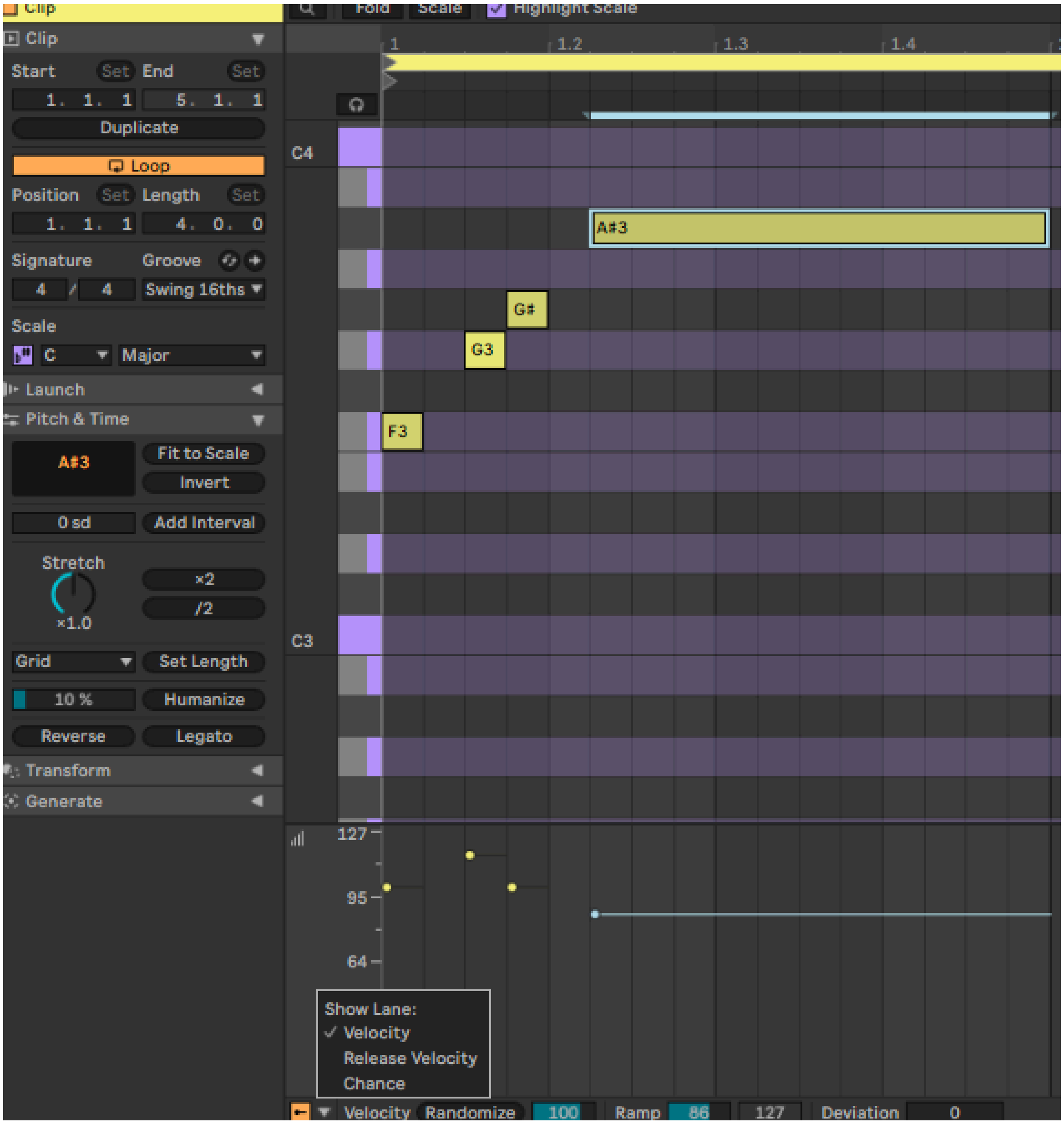
3. Connect a MIDI keyboard or use your computer keyboard.
4. Record your melody by pressing record and playing the note or create a new MIDI clip and draw the notes in yourself.



5. Humanize your MIDI recording:

- Open the piano roll or MIDI editor
- Adjust note velocities (how hard each note is played) to vary between 60-110
- Slightly shift note timing off the grid (±5-10 milliseconds) for a natural feel



Step 3: Find Musical Inspiration

Objective: Analyze existing songs to understand what makes them work.

Analysis Process:

1. Create a playlist of 5-10 songs in your target genre.
2. Listen to each song with a notepad and write down:
    a. What makes the drums interesting? (patterns, sounds, fills)
    b. How does the bass move? (rhythm, note choices)
    c. What instruments/synths do they use? (synthesized sounds, piano, guitars)
    d. What background elements create atmosphere? (pads, effects, textures)
    e. When do elements enter and exit the song?
3. Import one reference track into your DAW on a separate track.
4. Use it as a volume and quality reference (mute it while producing).

Example:

The Weeknd's Starboy

- What makes the drums interesting? (patterns, sounds, fills)
    - Clap comes in during high energy parts.Drums stay pretty much the same throughout the track. The rim sounds and percussion drive the movement of the song.
- How does the bass move? (rhythm, note choices)
    - Plays a large part in the intro with a distorted sound but then fades into the background. Also during the breakdown between the drop and 2nd half.
- What instruments/synths do they use? (synthesized sounds, piano, guitars)
    - Simple notes/chords on the piano. Vocoder effect
- What background elements create atmosphere? (pads, effects, textures)
    - Delay, Reverb on the vocals.
- When do elements enter and exit the song?
    - Distorted Bass, Vocoder effect, Melody in the background during high energy parts.

Learning from Existing Songs:

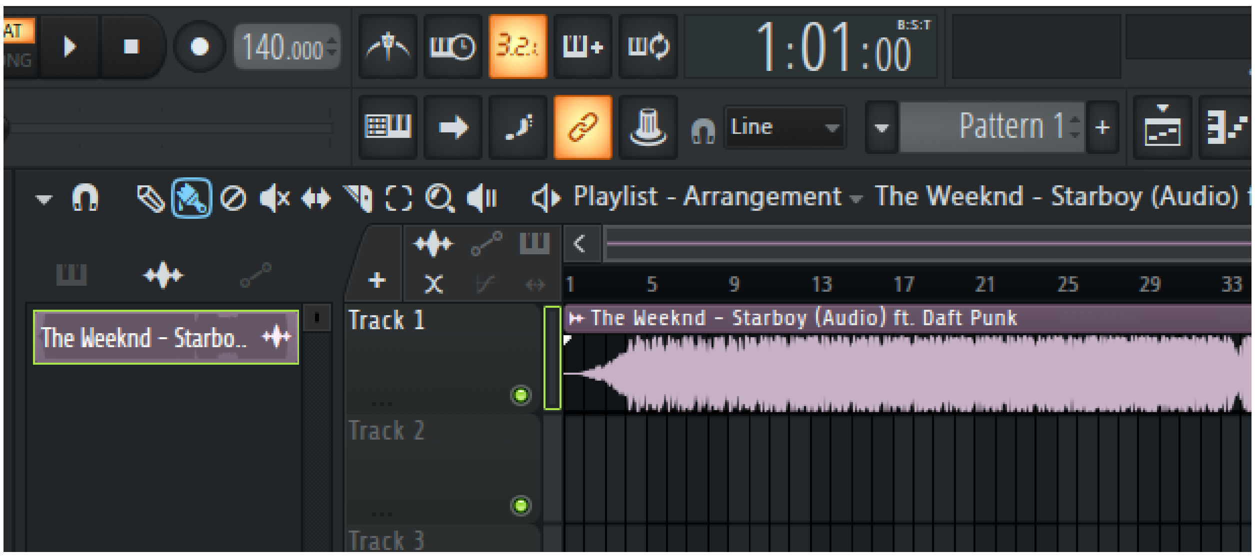
Extracting Drum Patterns:

1. Note that drum patterns are not copyrightable—you can learn from any song's rhythm.
2. Listen to the kick drum pattern and recreate it in your DAW.
3. Add the snare/clap pattern on a separate track.

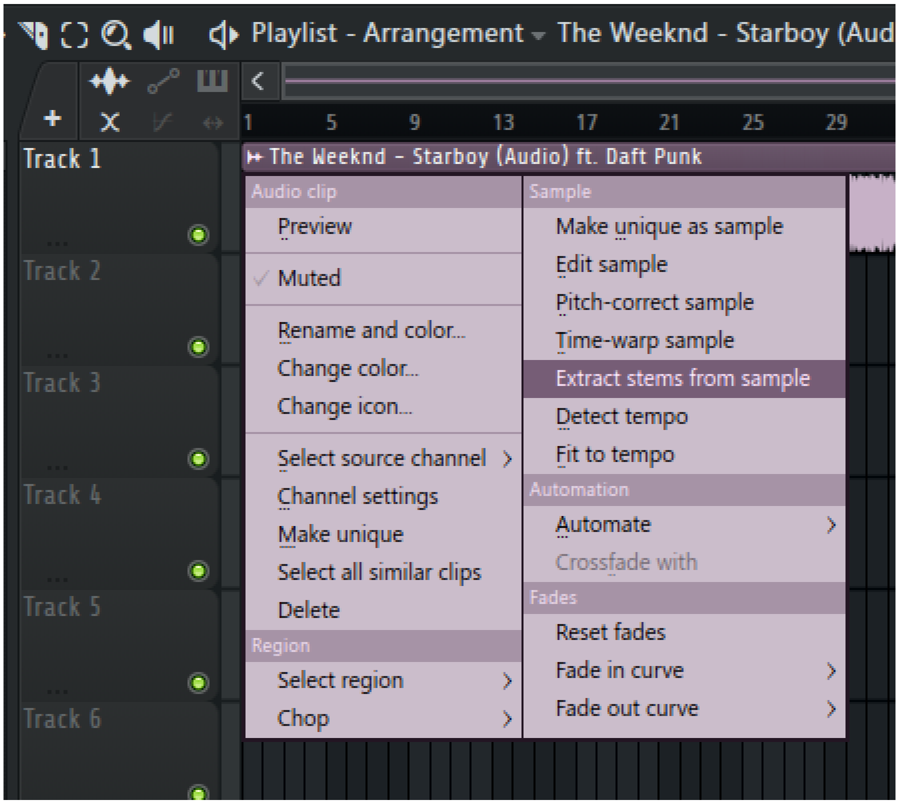
4. Layer in hi-hats, percussion, snares, even kicks. Layering allows you to take the parts of the drum sounds you like and combine them with other sounds. (e.g Snare + Clap, Clap + Snap, Kick + Click to make it punchy, etc.)
5. Substitute your own drum sounds to make it original.

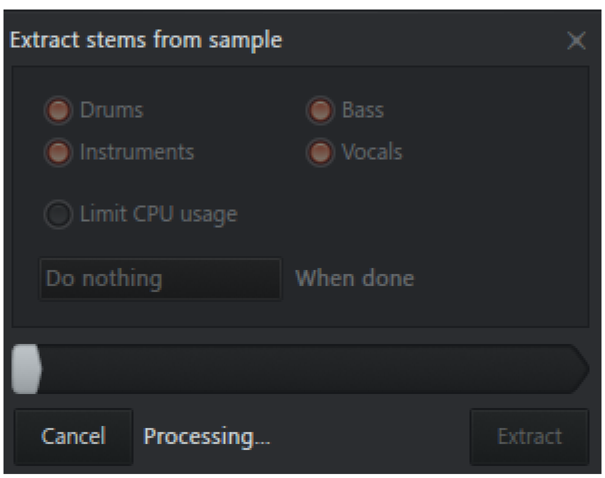
Using Stem Separation (FL Studio, Ableton, etc.): (Available in FL, Ableton in Beta for 12.3)

1. Import a full song into your DAW.

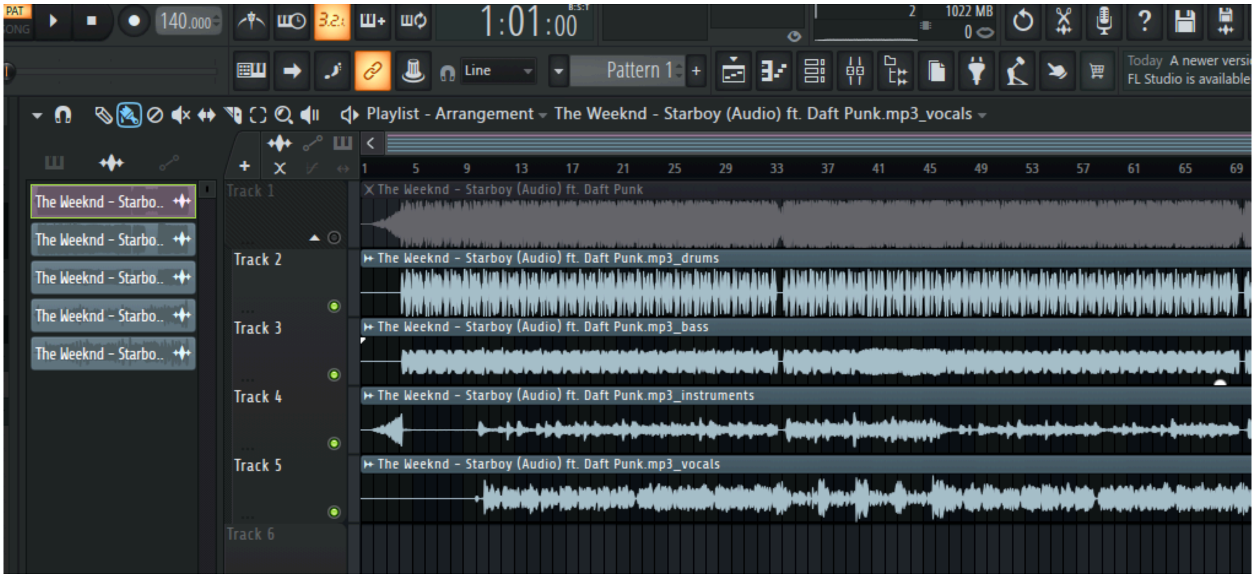


2. Use the built-in stem separation tool to extract individual tracks.





3. Listen to isolated drums, vocals, bass, and other instruments.



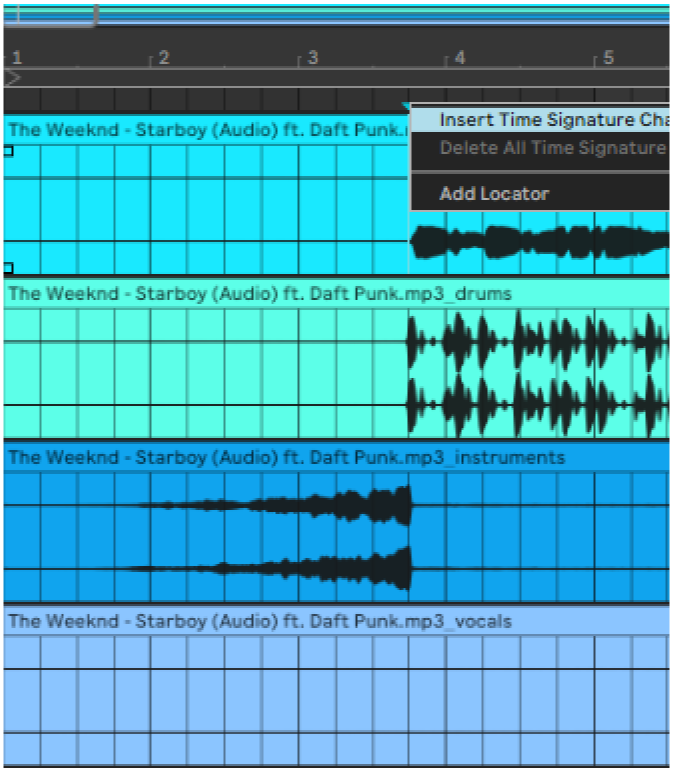
4. Study how each element fits into the arrangement.

Pro Tip: Remix a song with vocals, then remove the vocals at the end. You'll have created an original instrumental while learning song structure.

Step 4: Plan Your Song Structure

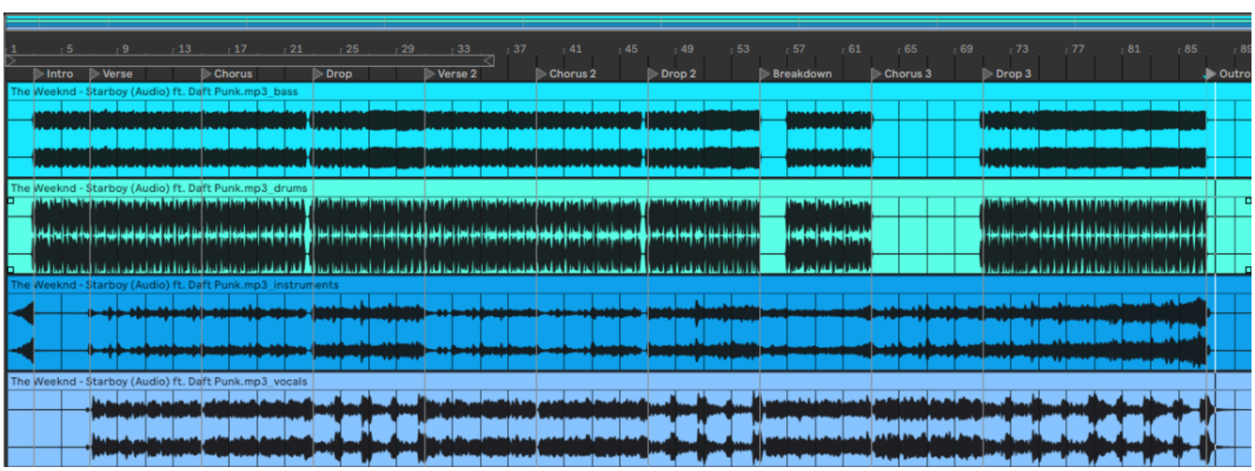
Objective: Decide on the arrangement before you start detailed production.

Common Song Structures:



Traditional Structure (Pop/Hip-Hop):

- Intro (4-8 bars)
- Verse 1 (8-16 bars)
- Chorus (8 bars)
- Verse 2 (8-16 bars)
- Chorus (8 bars)
- Bridge (4-8 bars)
- Final Chorus (8 bars)
- Outro (4-8 bars)



Modern Two-Part Structure:

1. Create your first section (Part A) with one set of sounds and energy.
2. At the halfway point (around 1:30-2:00), switch to Part B with different sounds but maintain the same feel or key.
3. This structure, popularized by artists like Drake and Travis Scott, keeps listeners engaged for the full duration.

Electronic Music Drop Structures:

ABAB Pattern:

- Section A: 4-8 bars with main melody
- Section B: 4-8 bars with variation (different notes, same sounds)
- Repeat A, then repeat B

ABAC Pattern:

- Section A: 4-8 bars with main melody
- Section B: 4-8 bars with first variation
- Repeat A
- Section C: 4-8 bars with second variation (more different from A)

Planning Your Track:

1. Use arrangement markers in your DAW.
2. Place markers at each section change in your DAW timeline.
3. Decide which instruments to add/remove in each section.

Step 5: Build Your Foundation (Drums and Bass)

Objective: Start with the rhythmic and low-end foundation of your track.

Creating the Drum Track:

1. Create a new MIDI or audio track for your kick drum.
2. Place kick drum hits on beats 1 and 3 (or create your own pattern).
3. Create another track for snare/clap and place hits on beats 2 and 4.
4. Add a hi-hat track with 8th or 16th note patterns.
5. Layer in additional percussion (shakers, tambourines, claps) for texture.
6. Add drum fills at the end of every 4-8 bars to create movement.

Adding the Bassline:

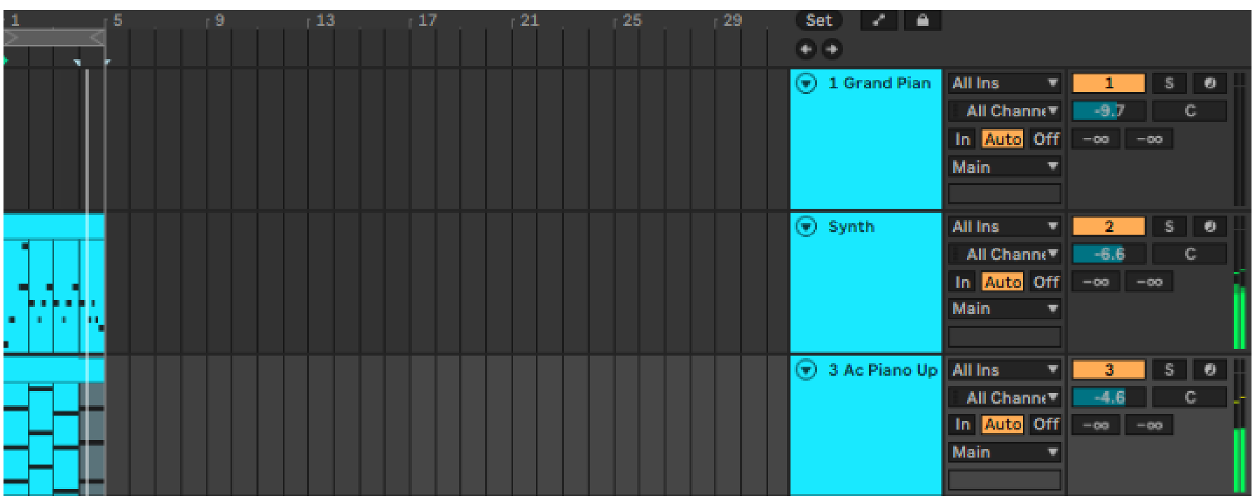
1. Create a new MIDI track and load a bass instrument or sample.
2. Find the key of your song (C minor, G major, etc.).
3. Program or play bass notes that emphasize beats 1 and 3.
4. Keep bass notes simple—often just the root notes of your chord progression work best.
5. Adjust the length of bass notes (short and punchy vs. long and sustained) to fit your genre.

Step 6: Layer Melodic and Harmonic Elements

Objective: Add the musical content that carries the emotion of your track.

Adding Melodies:

1. Create a new track for your lead melody (synth, piano, guitar, etc.).
2. Play or program a simple 2-4 bar melody.
3. Keep melodies in the middle to high frequency range (above the bass).
4. Use space—not every bar needs to be filled with melody.



Creating Harmonic Support:

1. Add chord pads or strings on a new track.
2. Play sustained chords that change every 2-4 bars.
3. Keep pads in the background by reducing their volume.
4. Apply reverb to pads to create depth and atmosphere.

Layering Texture:

1. Add atmospheric elements: white noise sweeps, vinyl crackle, ambient sounds.
2. Include occasional sound effects that match your genre.
3. Place texture elements in the stereo field (panned left and right) to create width.

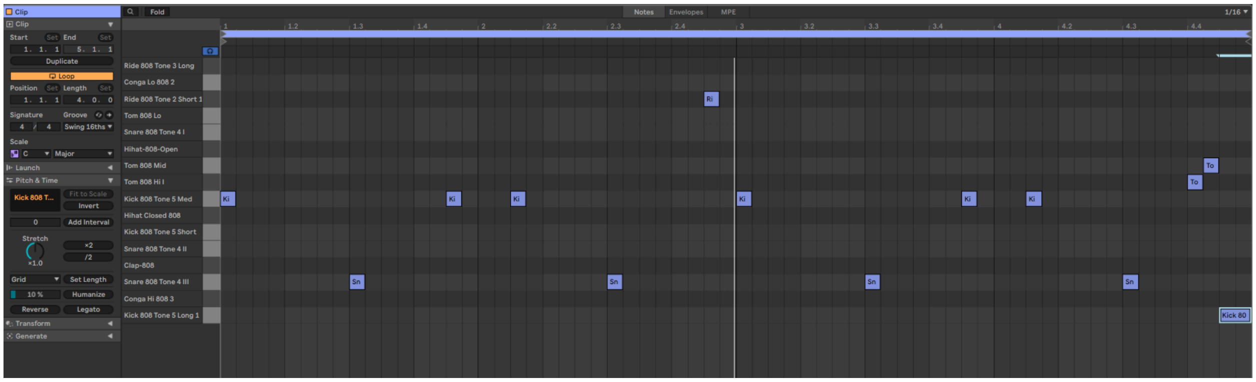
Step 7: Design Smooth Transitions

Objective: Create seamless movement between sections of your song.

Transition Techniques:

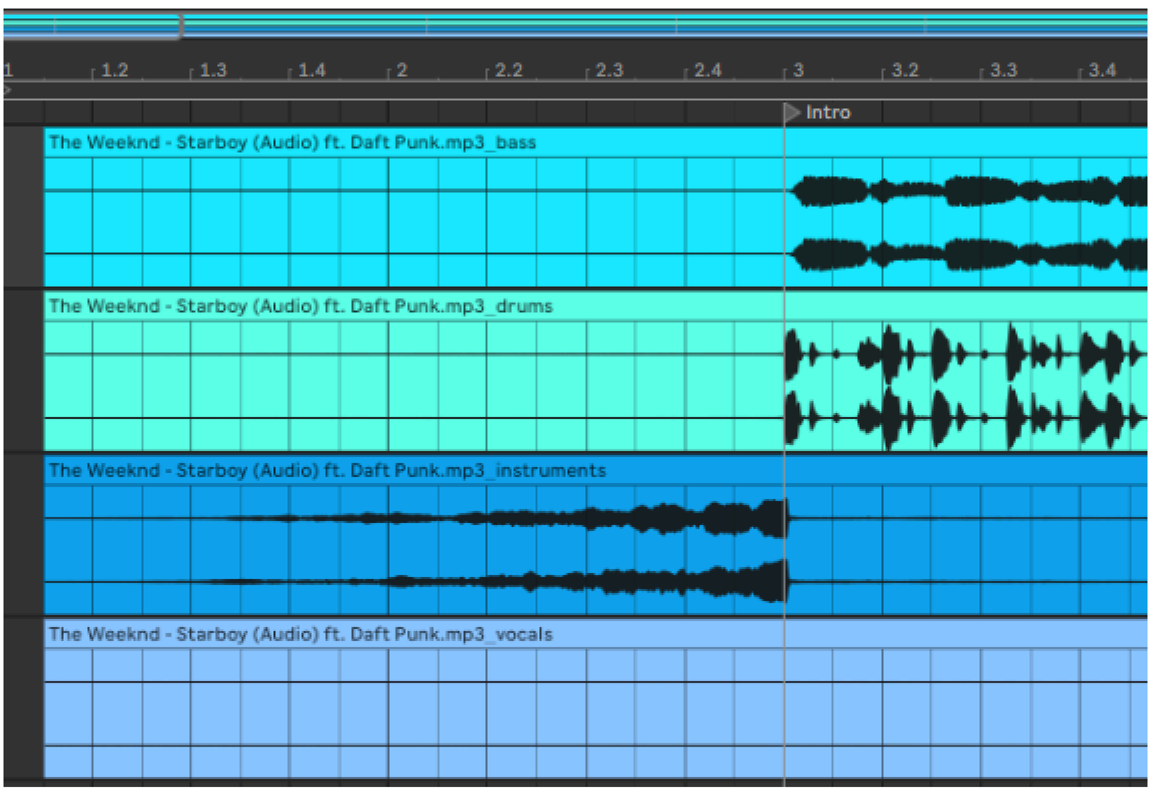
Drum Fills:

1. At the end of every 8-bar section, create a 1-2 bar drum fill.
2. Use tom drums, snare rolls, or cymbal crashes.
3. Increase the rhythm complexity leading into the new section.



Risers and Sweeps:

1. Add white noise or synthesizer risers that increase in pitch and volume.
2. Start the riser 2-4 bars before the section change.
3. End the riser exactly when the new section starts.



Filtering and Automation:

1. Select a track that plays continuously through the transition.
2. Apply a low-pass filter and automate it to open up at the section change.
3. Automate the volume to drop slightly before the transition, then boost at the change.

Impact and Drop Silence:

1. Create a moment of silence (1/4 to 1 beat) right before a major drop or section change.
2. Add an impact sound effect (hit, boom, crash) at the moment of change.

Step 8: Clean Up Frequency Conflicts (EQ and Mixing)

Objective: Remove clashing frequencies so each element has its own space.

EQ Basics:

1. Open an equalizer (EQ) plugin on each track.
2. Apply a high-pass filter to remove unnecessary low frequencies:
   - Vocals, synths, guitars: Cut below 80-100 Hz
   - Pads and strings: Cut below 100-150 Hz
   - Hi-hats and cymbals: Cut below 200-300 Hz
3. Leave low frequencies only for kick drum and bass.

Removing Frequency Conflicts:

1. Identify which elements clash (usually bass and kick, or vocals and synths).
2. On the bass track, cut a narrow band (2-5 dB) at the kick drum's main frequency (usually 50-80 Hz).
3. On melodic elements, cut slightly in the 200-500 Hz range if they compete with vocals or lead instruments.
4. Boost frequencies only when necessary to add presence or brightness.

Frequency Ranges Guide:

- Sub bass: 20-60 Hz (kick drum, bass)
- Bass: 60-250 Hz (bass guitar, lower synths)
- Low mids: 250-500 Hz (warmth, body)
- Mids: 500 Hz-2 kHz (vocals, guitars, fundamental notes)
- High mids: 2-5 kHz (presence, clarity)
- Highs: 5-20 kHz (air, sparkle, cymbals)

Step 9: Balance Your Mix

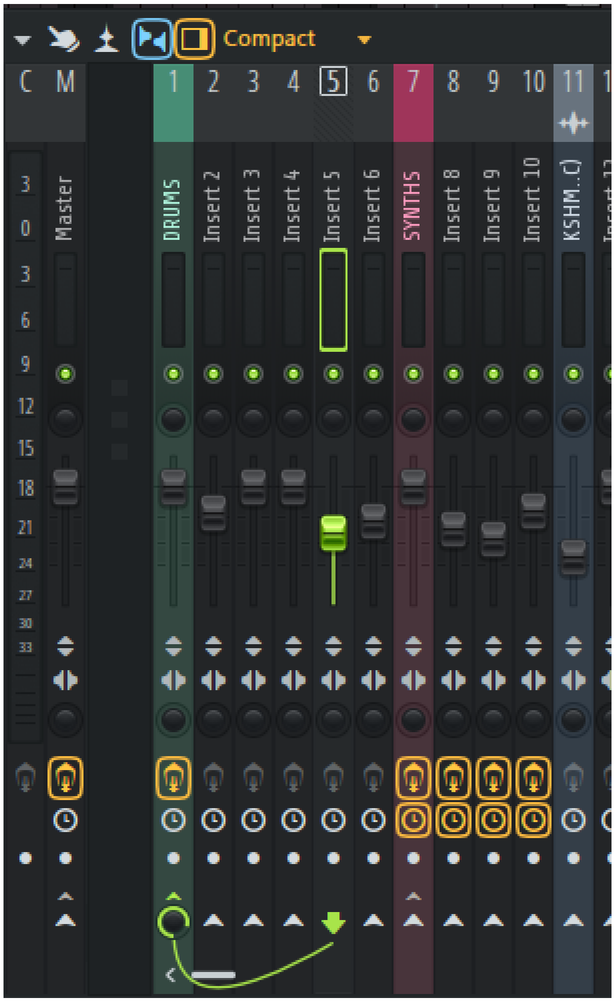
Objective: Adjust volume levels so important elements stand out while everything remains clear.

Setting Levels:

1. Start with all faders (volume sliders) at their lowest position.
2. Bring up the most important element first (usually vocals or lead melody) to -6 dB on the master meter.
3. Bring up the kick drum until it feels balanced with the lead element.
4. Add the bass until it supports the kick without overpowering it.
5. Layer in remaining elements from most to least important.
6. Keep your master output between -6 dB and -3 dB to leave headroom.

Creating Depth with Volume:

- Foreground (loudest): Lead vocals, main melody, kick, snare
- Midground (medium): Bass, supporting melodies, important effects
- Background (quietest): Pads, ambient sounds, reverb tails, texture



Panning for Width:

1. Keep kick, bass, snare, and lead vocals in the center (pan = 0).
2. Pan supporting elements slightly left or right (10-30%).
3. Pan wide elements hard left and right (70-100%) like stereo pads or reverb returns.
4. Balance panning so both sides feel equal in weight.

Step 10: Apply Master Chain Processing

Objective: Add final polish to glue all elements together.

Master Chain Order:

1. EQ (subtle adjustments only)
2. Compression (light, 2-3 dB gain reduction max)
3. Limiter (prevents clipping and adds loudness)

Applying Master Processing:

Master EQ:

1. Insert an EQ on the master channel.
2. Apply a gentle high-pass filter at 30 Hz to remove rumble.
3. Add a subtle high-shelf boost (+1 to +2 dB at 10 kHz) for airiness if needed.

Master Compression:

1. Insert a compressor on the master channel after the EQ.
2. Set ratio to 2:1 or 3:1.
3. Set attack to medium-slow (20-30 ms).
4. Set release to auto or 100-200 ms.
5. Adjust threshold so the gain reduction barely moves (1-3 dB maximum).

Master Limiter:

1. Insert a limiter as the last plugin in the chain.
2. Set the ceiling to -0.3 dB to prevent clipping.
3. Bring up the input gain until your track reaches appropriate loudness.
4. Watch for distortion—back off if you hear crackling or harshness.

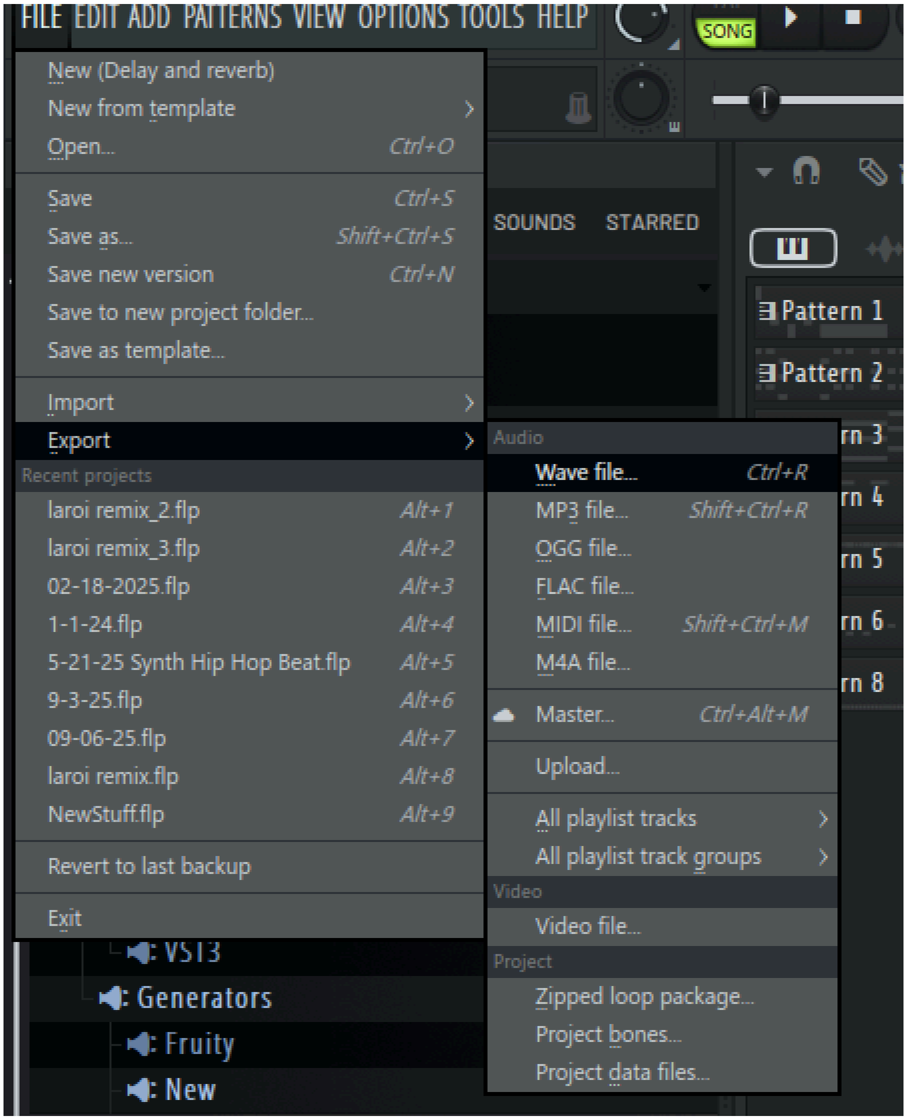
5. Compare your master's loudness to your reference track.

Step 11: Export Your Final Track

Objective: Prepare your song for sharing and distribution.

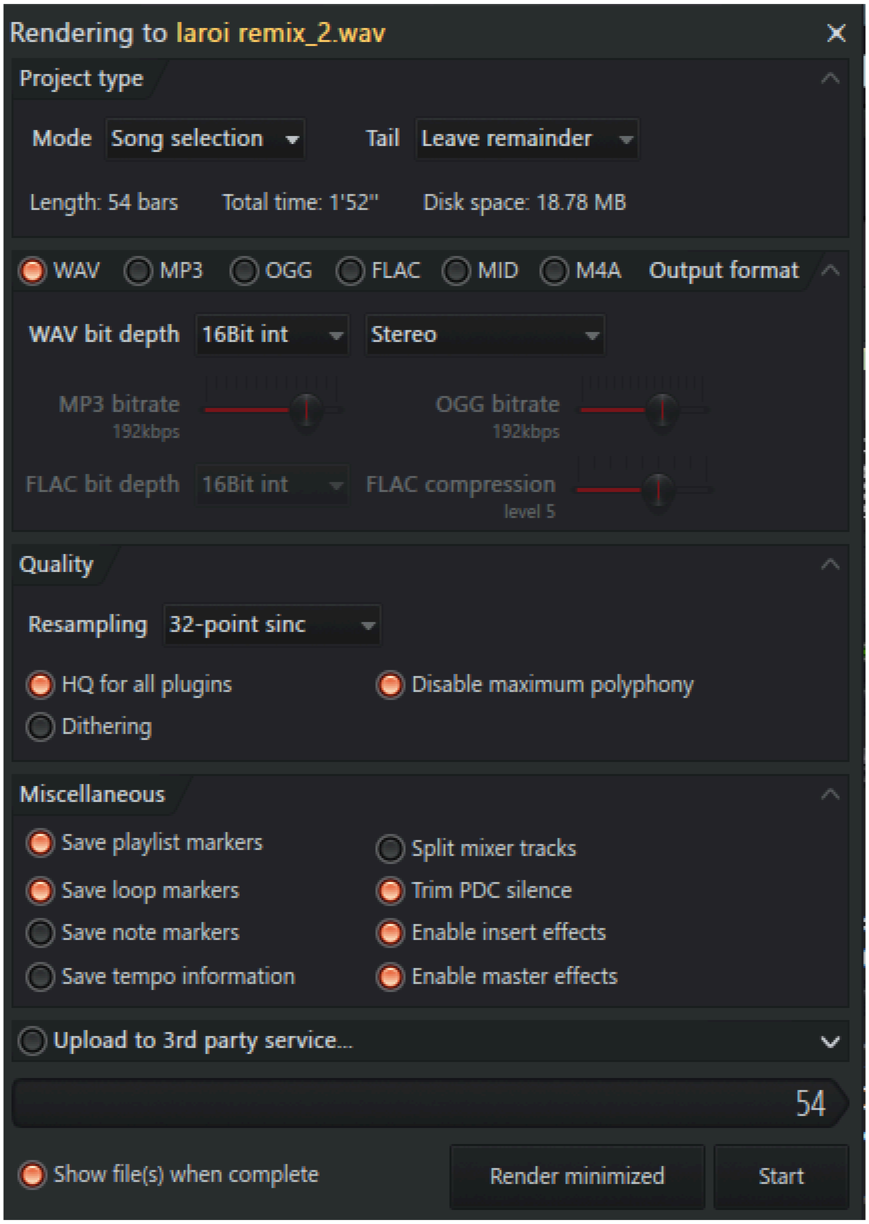
Export Settings:

1. Go to File > Export or Bounce/Render.
2. Choose WAV format for highest quality.
3. Select 24-bit depth and 44.1 kHz or 48 kHz sample rate.
4. Name your file clearly: "ArtistName_SongTitle_Final_Date"
5. Export with all effects and processing enabled.
6. Listen to the exported file on different playback systems (phone, car, headphones).



Creating an MP3 Version:

1. Use an audio converter or re-export as MP3.
2. Select 320 kbps for best quality.
3. Add metadata (song title, artist name, year) if desired.



Troubleshooting Common Issues

Problem: Mix sounds muddy or unclear

Apply high-pass filters more aggressively. Cut low-mid frequencies (200-400 Hz) slightly on multiple tracks.

Problem: Mix sounds harsh or fatiguing

Reduce high frequencies (5-10 kHz) slightly across multiple tracks. Check if the master limiter is working too hard.

Problem: Some parts are too quiet, others too loud

Revisit Step 9 and rebalance. Use compression on individual tracks to control dynamic range.

Problem: Bass disappears on small speakers

Add harmonics to bass (saturation/distortion) or layer a higher "bass note" octave. Test on phone speakers.

Problem: Song feels boring or repetitive

Add more variation in drums (fills, changes). Introduce new elements every 8-16 bars. Adjust arrangement.

Glossary of Terms

BPM (Beats Per Minute): The tempo of your song. Higher BPM = faster song.

DAW (Digital Audio Workstation): Software used to record, edit, and produce music.

EQ (Equalizer): A tool that adjusts specific frequency ranges to shape the tone of a sound.

High-Pass Filter: An EQ setting that removes frequencies below a certain point.

MIDI (Musical Instrument Digital Interface): A protocol for communicating musical information between devices.

Panning: Positioning a sound in the stereo field (left to right).

Reverb: An effect that simulates the sound of a space by adding reflections and ambience.

Sample: A recorded sound (drum hit, melody, instrument) used in production.

Stem: An isolated track from a song (drums only, vocals only, etc.).

VST (Virtual Studio Technology): A software plugin that adds instruments or effects to your DAW.

Conclusion

Congratulations on completing your first music production! Remember that creating music is a skill that improves with practice. Each song you make will be better than the last as you develop your ear and learn what works for your style.

Next Steps:

- Create 5-10 more tracks to solidify these skills
- Study music theory basics to improve your melodies and chords
- Join online music production communities for feedback
- Experiment with different genres and techniques